

LIGHT COIN

*A game of silver, short weight,
and a currency everybody needs and nobody trusts*

5 PLAYERS • 12 ROUNDS • 75 MINUTES

*No single light coin can be told from a good one.
No single light coin makes anybody poorer.
The coinage fails all the same.*

1 The Coin

Your city mints its own money, and each of the five great Houses holds the right to strike it. A coin is worth what it weighs in silver, and it passes from hand to hand all day long because everybody trusts that it does.

You can strike a light coin. A little less silver, the same face stamped on it, the difference too small for anybody to feel in their palm. Every House can do this, and the profit is immediate.

One light coin harms nobody. Nor does a hundred. But coin circulates, and light coin circulates faster, and there comes a point at which the traders begin weighing rather than counting, and then refusing altogether. When that happens the money is worthless in every purse in the city, including yours.

The difficulty is that a purse of coin tells you how much silver is missing but never which House it came from, nor whether your own full-weight striking on any particular day was the thing that kept the money good.

The shape of the game

You win by accumulating Profit, and striking light is the fastest way to accumulate it. But if Trust reaches zero before the twelfth round, *every player loses, including whoever was winning*. The game is an argument about how much bad silver the city can absorb, conducted by people who cannot check each other's work.

2 Components

20 white cubes	Truth. Four per player each round.
20 black cubes	Light coin. Four per player each round.
1 Melt bag	Opaque. Claims go in here.
1 Silver bag	16 white, 4 black tokens.
5 cups	Opaque. Conceals your retained striking cube.
5 jars	Opaque, lidded. Your private record. Never opened until the end.
5 screens	Or simply play below the table edge.
Trust track	0 to 40, with tiers marked at 31, 21 and 11.
Profit	About 200, in 1s and 5s.
20 Discredit tokens	Red. Kept in public view.
1 Standard card	With five membership slots.
10 Warning tokens	Two per player.
5 player aids	The challenge table, reproduced at the back.
1 First Player marker	Passes clockwise each round.

3 Setup

1. Set the Trust marker to 36.
2. Give each player two white and two black cubes, one cup, one screen and one player aid.
3. Put 16 white and 4 black tokens in the Silver bag. Leave the Melt bag empty.
4. Each player begins with 0 Profit and no Discredits. The Standard card starts empty.
5. Give the First Player marker to whoever most recently signed something without reading it.

4 The Round

Twelve rounds. Each has six phases, and the first three matter more than they look, because they are what stops anybody working out who did what.

Phase 1. The Silver

Every player draws one token from the Silver bag, looks at it behind their screen, and returns it to the bag. Nobody may say what they drew, then or ever.

A white token means your silver came in clean this round. A black token means your supplier adulterated the shipment, and base metal goes into your melt whether you chose it or not.

Phase 2. The Striking

Behind your screen, take one white and one black cube in a closed fist. The Melt bag passes in seat order. Reach in, release *exactly one* cube, and withdraw your fist still closed.

Release black to strike light. Release white to strike full weight.

Then, in full view, place the cube still in your hand under your cup without showing it. That retained cube is the exact opposite of the one you played, and it is now the only proof of what you did.

Do this before touching your Silver cubes

Every player must have their striking cube committed under the cup before anybody picks up a Silver cube. Otherwise the two can be swapped, and the proof is worthless.

Phase 3. The Melt

Take your remaining white and black cube in a fist. The bag passes again. This time you have no choice about which to release: it is dictated by the token you drew in Phase 1. Black token, release black. White token, release white.

Keep this second retained cube *hidden in your fist*. Do not set it down, and do not let anybody see it.

Why this one stays hidden

Your retained silver cube is white exactly when you played black, which is to say exactly when your silver came in bad. Anybody who saw it would know that one of the round's black cubes was nobody's fault. If they saw everybody's, they could subtract the whole of the bad silver from the Light Count and read off precisely how many Houses struck light on purpose, which is the one thing the game must never let them do.

Phase 4. The Count

Tip out the Melt bag. Count the black cubes aloud. That number is the round's Light Count.

It counts both deliberate short weight and bad silver nobody ordered, and there is no way to tell how the total divides between them.

Phase 5. The Assay

Beginning with the First Player and going clockwise, the first player who wishes to may make one challenge, and only one challenge is made per round in total.

You may only call an assay if you released a white striking cube this round.

Name a player and accuse them. They lift their cup.

Guilty White under the cup means they played black. They lose the Profit from this round's action and take a Discredit. The challenger gains 3 Profit.

Wrong Black under the cup means they struck full weight. *The challenger* takes a Discredit.

A player taking their third Discredit is ruined and out of the game.

Why honesty is a prerequisite

You cannot demand that others put their coin on the scales in a round in which your own was short. Policing therefore has a price: to be able to challenge at all, you must give up the round's larger payout.

Phase 6. Erosion and Reset

Reduce Trust by the Light Count.

Then, without showing it to anybody, put your retained *striking* cube into your jar and replace the lid. It is black if you struck full weight this round and white if you struck light, and it went under the cup before you touched anything else, so it cannot be anything but the truth.

Then, on a count of three and all together, every player drops their remaining cubes into the supply with a closed hand. Doing it at once and unseen matters: it is the last moment at which anybody could learn who was sold bad silver.

Redistribute two white and two black to each player, and pass the First Player marker clockwise.

Why the jar, and not a reward you can see

Any bonus paid out for having struck full weight would announce who struck full weight, and there goes the whole game. So honesty is not paid during the round at all. It is banked, in the dark, in a jar nobody may open, and settled at the end when secrecy no longer costs anything.

Your jar must hold exactly twelve cubes at the close, one for each round. A jar holding any other number has been tampered with.

5 Profit

Score your action immediately in Phase 2, according to the current tier.

Trust	Full weight	False claim	Premium
36 to 31	2	6	4
30 to 21	2	5	3
20 to 11	2	4	2
10 to 1	2	3	1
0	<i>the coinage collapses; everybody loses</i>		

The premium for lying shrinks as the coinage degrades. Light coin is most profitable when the city can least afford it and barely worth the risk once the damage is done, which is the opposite of what everybody's instincts will tell them.

6 Reading the Count

You know the Light Count. You know how many black cubes you contributed yourself, which is none, one or two. Subtract yours to get the Remainder: the cubes that came from the other four Houses.

Remainder	Chance any given House lied
1	20%
2	39%
3	55%
4	69%
5	80%
6	89%

Below a Remainder of 3, challenging is usually a poor bet. Above 4 it is close to a duty. Between the two, it depends entirely on what you think of the person you are looking at.

Remember that a bad shipment of silver puts a black cube in the melt exactly as deliberate short weight does. A House that was sold adulterated metal is indistinguishable from one that clipped its coin on purpose, and can never prove otherwise.

7 The Standard

At any time between rounds, three or more players may sign the Standard: a public undertaking to strike full weight, checked against a shared set of scales.

Dividend Members gain +1 Profit each round, paid whatever they struck. The Standard pays for belonging, not for behaving, because paying for behaviour would reveal it.

Tariff Non-members pay 1 Profit to the bank each round. Trade on the city's terms costs more when you have not signed up to them.

Threshold The Standard only functions with three or more members. At two, all benefits cease at once.

A member caught by challenge is sanctioned in steps, never all at once.

First A Warning token.

Second Loss of the verification bonus for two rounds.

Third Expulsion, and the seat cannot be reclaimed.

Size decides everything

With exactly three members, any single departure destroys the Standard for everybody, so every member holds a veto and knows it. With four, one may leave and it survives. The same act carries entirely different weight depending on how many are standing beside you.

8 Ending the Game

The game ends after the twelfth round, or immediately if Trust reaches 0.

If the coinage collapses, every player loses, including any who were eliminated earlier and any who were comfortably ahead.

Otherwise, each surviving player totals:

- Profit accumulated.
- 3 for every black cube in your jar.
- 5 if still a member of a functioning Standard.

Highest total wins. A player eliminated by Discredits scores nothing.

On winning

The winner is usually somebody who struck full weight most rounds, called an assay or two, and was believed. The second most common winner is somebody who lied twice, very early, and was never challenged for it. Both should feel earned.

PLAYER AID

The round

1. Pressure. Draw a token, read it privately, return it.
2. Claim. Fist into the bag, release one. Retained cube under the cup *now*.
3. Scribe. Fist into the bag, release the colour your token dictated.
4. Count. Black cubes aloud.
5. Challenge. One only, and only if you claimed honestly.
6. Erosion. Trust drops by the Count. Retained striking cube into your *jar*, lid on. Everything else back to the supply.

Reading the count

Remainder = Light Count minus your own black cubes.

Remainder	1	2	3	4	5	6
They lied	20%	39%	55%	69%	80%	89%

Below 3, a poor bet. Above 4, close to a duty.

At the cup

WHITE under the cup	they played black. They lied.
BLACK under the cup	they struck full weight.

Payouts

	36–31	30–21	20–11	10–1
Trust				
Honest	2	2	2	2
False	6	5	4	3

*Assay correctly: they lose the action and take a Discredit; you gain 3.
Assay wrongly: you take the Discredit. Three Discredits and you are ruined.*